DM–00 PORTFOLIO REVIEW · JUNE 2026

Outcomes over everything.

DREW MCFARLAND

PRODUCT & SERVICE DESIGN

2 CASE STUDIES · 30 MIN

DM–01 THE SHORT VERSION

If it shipped and the way people work didn't change, I count it as a miss.

User research	EMBEDDED WITH OPERATORS
Service design	BLUEPRINTS · EVENT STORMING
Product design	COMPLEX OPERATIONAL UI
Product strategy	METRICS · ALIGNMENT
Build	DESIGN → WORKING SOFTWARE

Nine years on government and defense software. USAF veteran — I was the user before I was the designer. M.S. in Human-Computer Interaction. Active Secret clearance. The two cases today are the two ends of my range: one deep on a single operational interface, one wide across an organization's seams.

2016
Service Design Consultant
DrewUX — independent

2017
Product Designer
USAF Kessel Run

2022
Design Operations Lead
USAF Kessel Run

2025
Sr Service Designer · Product Lead
Rise8

DM–02 FORMAT

Two case studies, told the same way.

BEFORE	The symptom I was handed	The stated task — and what researching it actually turned up.
THE TARGET	The outcome users needed	What good had to look like, once the real problem was clear.
WHAT I DID	The design moves, and the fights	Decisions, artifacts, and where I had to hold the line.
RESULT	What changed, measured	In adoption, hours, and independence — not in launch announcements.

01	JIGSAW	Aerial-refueling planning · USAF Kessel Run · product design depth	adopted by 1 → 4 AOCs
02	FORGE	Platform onboarding · Space Force / Rise8 · service design breadth	self-service 7% → 90%

JIGSAW.

A modernized planning tool that worked in one air operations center — and couldn't expand to a second. My job was to find out why.

ROLE	ORG	DURATION	TEAM	ENVIRONMENT
Lead UX Designer	USAF Kessel Run	8 months	8 people	Classified · screens sanitized

J–01 BEFORE

Modernized — and still stuck in one theater.

THE TASK

"We can't expand to other AOCs. Fix it."

A previous team had already "modernized" tanker planning for one air operations center. I was brought on for what came next — and handed a symptom, not a diagnosis.

THE CATCH

Modernized isn't the same as solved.

Off the spreadsheets, into a clean UI — but it was built around **one center's local process**, not the outcome planners need. Nothing in it earned a second AOC's adoption.

THE STAKES

Tanker planning is the day's fuel.

A late or wrong plan means receivers don't get gas — sorties cut, missions re-planned. A tool that can't travel leaves every other theater planning the hard way.

WHAT I KEPT HEARING

Other centers looked at it and didn't see their job in it — so they kept planning their own way.

J–02 THE TARGET · WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Two theaters, one job — I went looking for the difference.

I split time between the 613th (Pacific) and 609th (Central) Air Operations Centers — two theaters running the same mission their own ways. I followed the plan end to end in each, separating what **every** tanker planner needs from what one office happened to do.

THE REFRAME THAT SET THE DIRECTION

"Modernize the workflow" was the old goal — and the reason the tool couldn't travel. The real target: design for the outcome every planner needs — a fast, conflict-free, trustworthy plan — so it's worth adopting in any theater. Build for the outcome, not the office.

J–03 WHAT I DID · FRAMING

Design for what every planner needs, not what one office does.

TRUST

The plan checks itself.

A planner's core outcome is a plan they can trust. Conflicts validate as it's built — a double-booking flags the moment it's made, not after the phone rings. Every theater needs that; none of it is local.

CLARITY

Selection reveals connection.

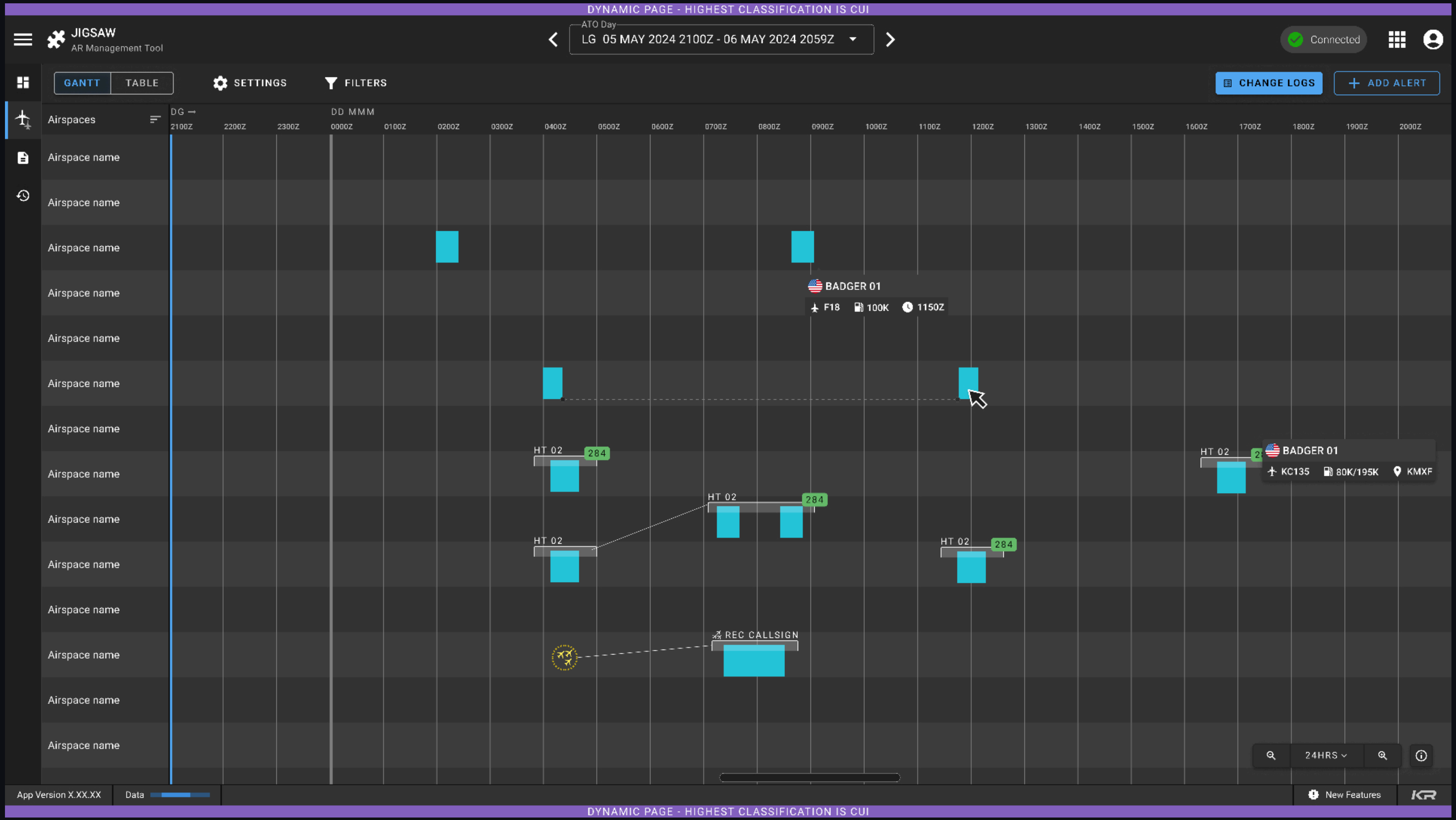
Click any sortie and everything it touches lights up — tankers, receivers, airspace. Managing dependencies is the job everywhere, so the ripple effects get drawn instead of remembered.

PORTABILITY

Shaped by the outcome, not the office.

The day at a glance, then filtered the way you actually slice it — modeled on what planning **produces**, not on one center's naming and steps. That's what let a second, third, and fourth AOC see their job in it.

J—04 WHAT I DID · THE PLANNING SURFACE



THE PLAN, IN THE TOOL

color-coded requests · dependencies drawn · conflicts flagged as they're made · sanitized (CUI)

J–05 WHAT I DID · TIME AND SPACE, ONE CANVAS

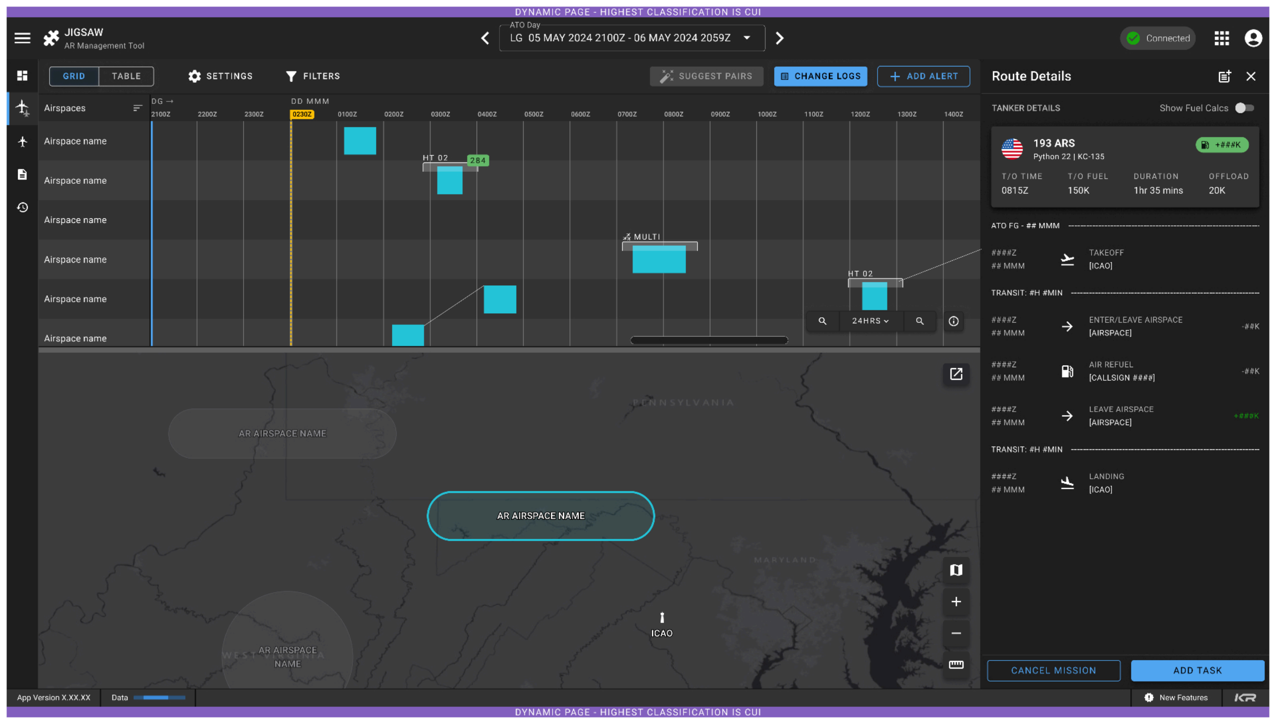
THE FIGHT WORTH HAVING

Engineering pushed back hard on connected highlighting — it cut across data relationships system-wide, and the estimate was ugly.

I held the line because it serves the planner's core outcome: **seeing what else moves when one thing moves.** That's the job in every theater — drop it and the tool is just a prettier form.

We kept the argument on observed work, not taste — and scoped it to ship: **highlight first, full dependency tracing later.**

IT SHIPPED IN V1.



SPLIT TIMELINE + MAP

synchronized selection · route details on demand

J–06 RESULT

One AOC became four — and the day got shorter in each.

AOCs ADOPTED — 1 →	DAILY PLANNING — 8+ HRS →	ONBOARDING — 4 WEEKS →	CONFLICTS MISSED — 90 DAYS
4	1.5 hrs	3 days	0
the tool finally traveled — the original mandate, met	done before the morning brief, not after it	new planners planning unsupervised	the tool catches what hand-checking missed

WHY ADOPTION WAS THE REAL TEST

A tool built for one office gets rebuilt for the next. One built on the outcome every planner shares just spreads — and planners rotate every 2–3 years, so the time it saves compounds.

FORGE.

A platform built to speed delivery — where reaching the warfighter still took eighteen to twenty-four months.

ROLE	ORG	DOMAIN	SCOPE
Service Designer	Rise8 · Space Force	DevSecOps platform	5 internal teams · multi-contractor

F—01 BEFORE

18–24 months from kickoff to the warfighter.

THE PROBLEM

No compliant, paved path to production.

The platform existed to get capability to the warfighter fast. It couldn't — standing a team up and reaching first deploy dragged on for months.

THE WASTE

Year-long contracts that delivered nothing.

A 12-month proof-of-concept contract could start and end with nothing in front of a user. No one's fault — but the government bought a year for no return, and the vendor had nothing to re-compete on.

THE TRAP

Two years of building, no feedback.

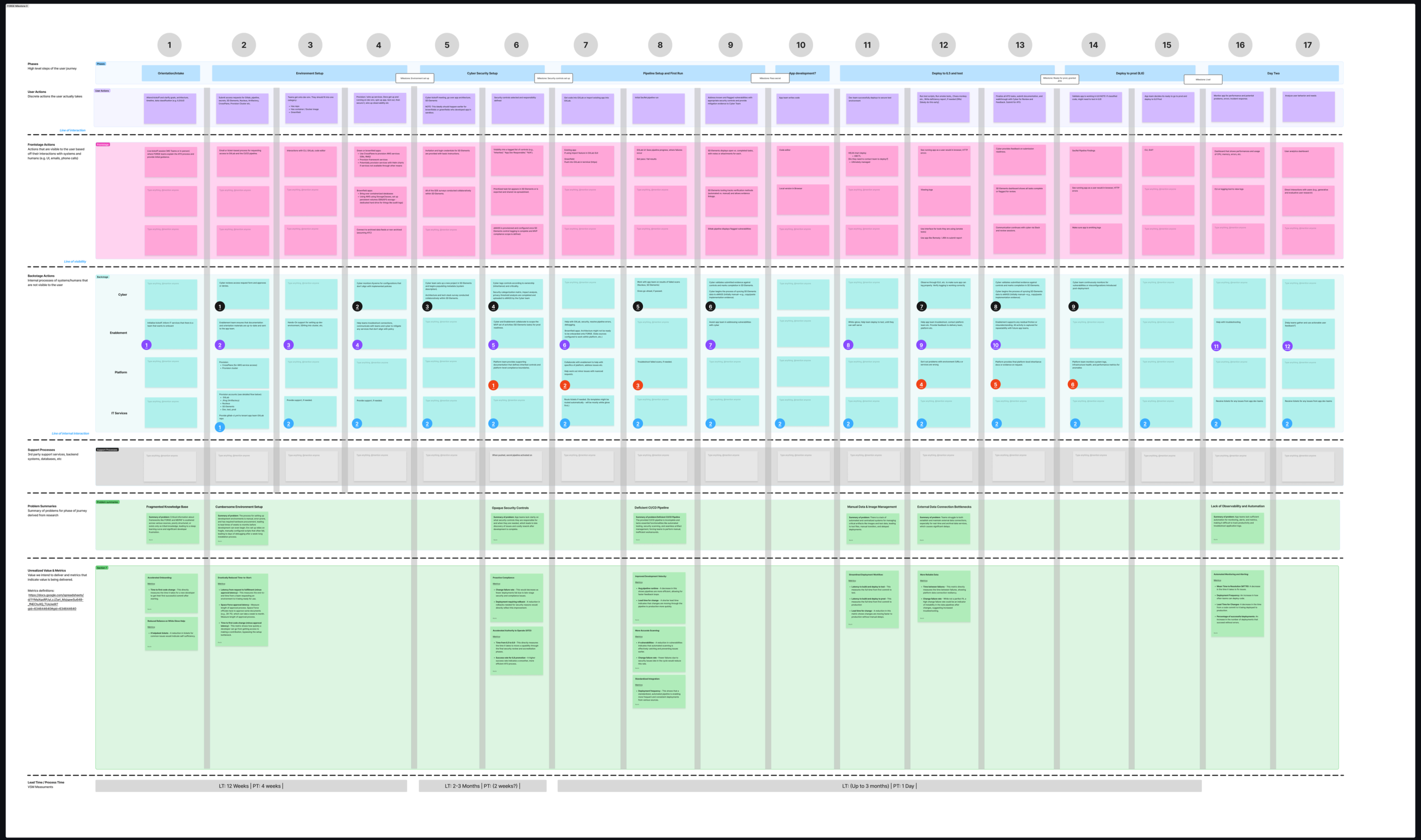
What reached the field after two years rarely got adopted — built that whole time without real user feedback. Slow delivery quietly broke the loop that makes software worth shipping.

MY SLICE · THE TARGET

Rise8 was brought in to pave the path. I owned onboarding — the front of it, where teams stalled for months. The target: onboard to first deploy in days, not months.

F–02 WHAT I DID · MAKE THE JOURNEY VISIBLE

You can't redesign what you can't see.



SERVICE BLUEPRINT — 17 PHASES × 4 LANES

tenant action · visible touchpoint · backstage work · support — the first shared picture five teams had

F–03 WHAT I DID · FROM ANECDOTES TO DATA

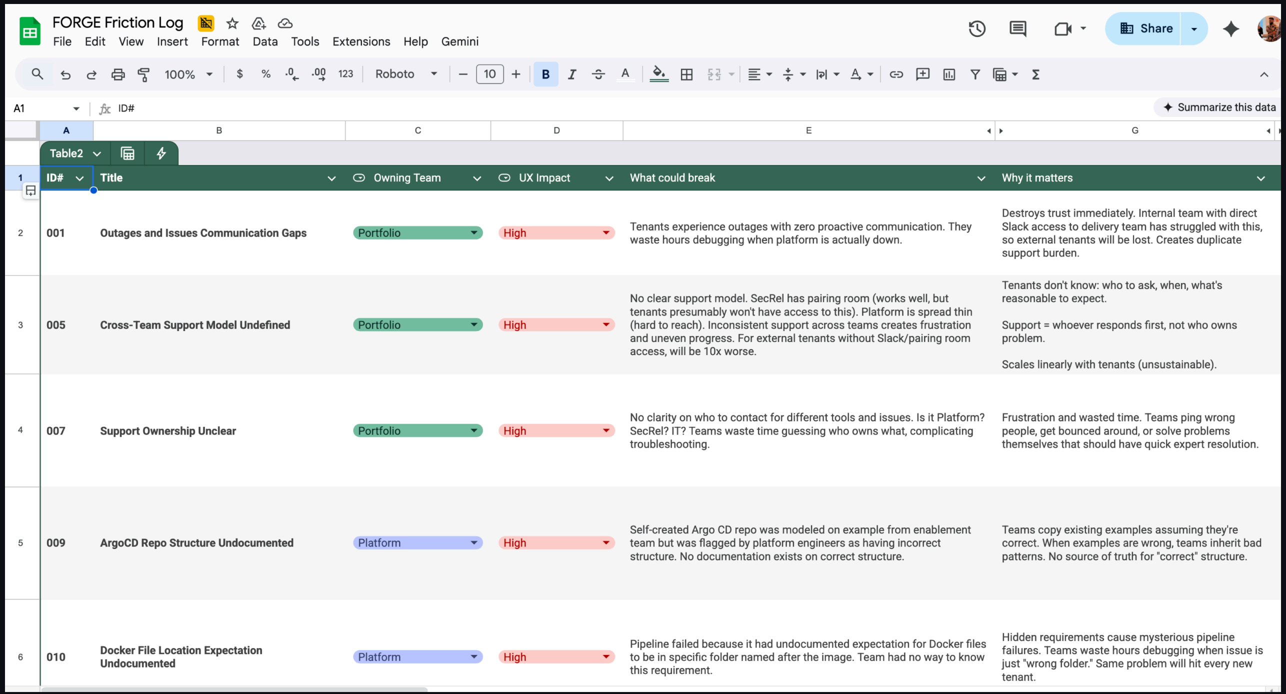
THE FRICTION LOG

Every tenant pain point scored on four fields before it could enter a meeting: **owning team · UX severity · breakage risk · rationale**.

"A tenant complained about X" became **"high-severity, breakage risk, owned by your team — here's why."** Meetings re-centered on what ranked highest, not what was argued loudest.

The repeating patterns shared a root: internal habits had quietly become unspoken requirements for people on the outside.

PAIRED WITH DDD EVENT STORMING OF THE INTERNAL FLOW



ID#	Title	Owning Team	UX Impact	What could break	Why it matters
001	Outages and Issues Communication Gaps	Portfolio	High	Tenants experience outages with zero proactive communication. They waste hours debugging when platform is actually down.	Destroys trust immediately. Internal team with direct Slack access to delivery team has struggled with this, so external tenants will be lost. Creates duplicate support burden.
005	Cross-Team Support Model Undefined	Portfolio	High	No clear support model. SecRel has pairing room (works well, but tenants presumably won't have access to this). Platform is spread thin (hard to reach). Inconsistent support across teams creates frustration and uneven progress. For external tenants without Slack/pairing room access, will be 10x worse.	Tenants don't know: who to ask, when, what's reasonable to expect. Support = whoever responds first, not who owns problem. Scales linearly with tenants (unsustainable).
007	Support Ownership Unclear	Portfolio	High	No clarity on who to contact for different tools and issues. Is it Platform? SecRel? IT? Teams waste time guessing who owns what, complicating troubleshooting.	Frustration and wasted time. Teams ping wrong people, get bounced around, or solve problems themselves that should have quick expert resolution.
009	ArgoCD Repo Structure Undocumented	Platform	High	Self-created Argo CD repo was modeled on example from enablement team but was flagged by platform engineers as having incorrect structure. No documentation exists on correct structure.	Teams copy existing examples assuming they're correct. When examples are wrong, teams inherit bad patterns. No source of truth for "correct" structure.
010	Docker File Location Expectation Undocumented	Platform	High	Pipeline failed because it had undocumented expectation for Docker files to be in specific folder named after the image. Team had no way to know this requirement.	Hidden requirements cause mysterious pipeline failures. Teams waste hours debugging when issue is just "wrong folder." Same problem will hit every new tenant.

FRICTION LOG

each row: owner · severity · breakage risk · rationale

F—04 WHAT I DID · THE PORTAL

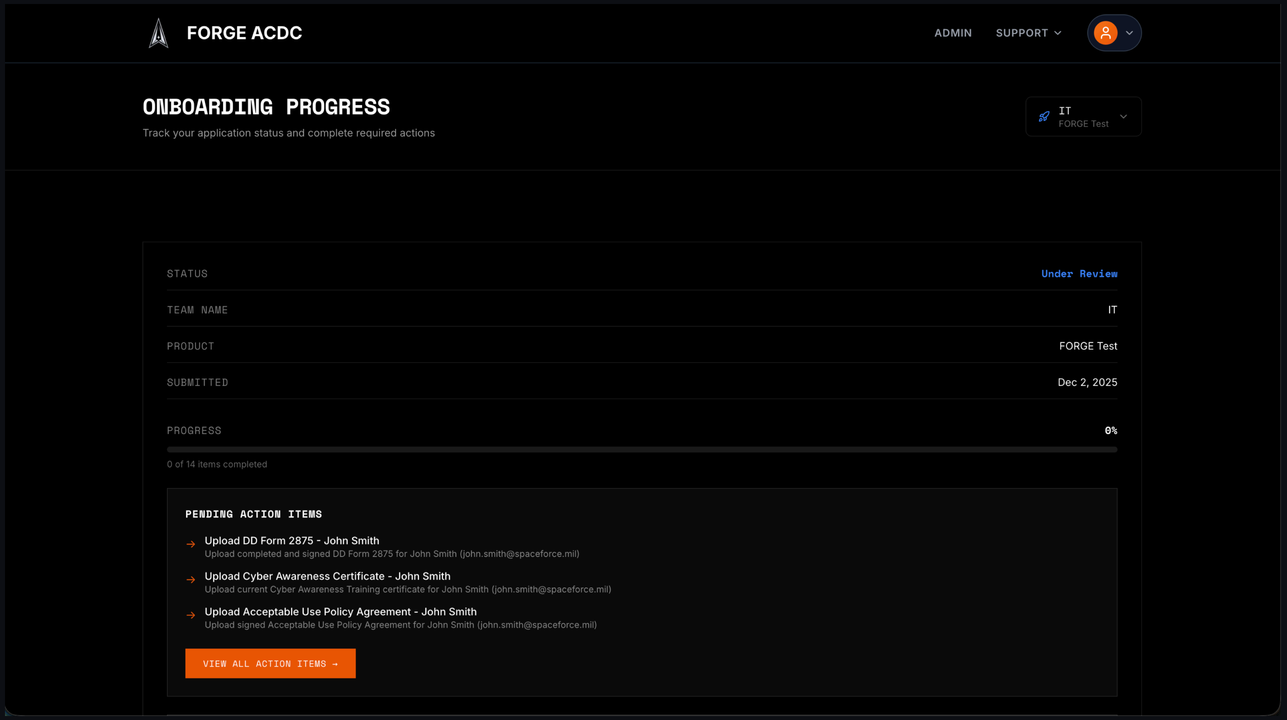
Built around the three questions tenants couldn't get answered.

Q—01 Where am I in the process?

Q—02 Who owns the next step?

Q—03 What can I do right now?

Status, ownership, next action — the spine of the design. A services hub put the full toolkit on one screen, each tool's access state beside it.



ONBOARDING PROGRESS status · assigned team · pending actions with owners

F—05 RESULT · THE ONBOARDING SLICE

Onboarding stopped being where the months disappeared.

SELF-SERVICE — 6-7% →	ONBOARD → 1ST DEPLOY — MONTHS →	SUPPORT TICKETS	TEAMS ONBOARDED
90%	4.5 days	-80%	8
most teams finish without a support handoff	past the original one-week target	"what's my status?" stopped reaching the queue	a repeatable path, not a bespoke rescue

WHY THE FRONT OF THE PATH MATTERED MOST

Compress onboarding and the whole timeline moves — teams reach real users sooner, so feedback starts before the design calcifies. That's the loop the 18–24-month cycle had broken.

DM–03 THE COMMON THREAD

I was handed a symptom both times. The work was finding the outcome.

THE SYMPTOM

The brief is never the problem.

"Modernize tanker planning." "We can't expand to other AOCs." "Onboarding is too slow." Each one is real — and each one is a symptom, not the outcome anyone actually needs.

THE OUTCOME

Find what users need to achieve, then design only for that.

A plan any planner can trust and adopt. A path a team can actually get through. I research until the real outcome is clear — then cut everything that isn't it.

THE PROOF

The outcome shows up in how the work changes.

One AOC became four. Onboarding went from months to days. Not a launch announcement — **the way people work changed.**

LATELY I also ship what I design — **Velveteen**, a deploy pipeline with a visible security gate, designed and built end-to-end. Live at `velveteen.sh` · happy to go there in Q&A.

DM–04 THANK YOU

Questions — especially the hard ones.

DREW MCFARLAND
DREWJMCFARLAND2@GMAIL.COM

JIGSAW · FORGE · (VELVETEEN ON REQUEST)